

Shift

Platform Research & Product Documentation

Product	Shift — Blue Collar Seasonal Worker Marketplace
Market	Quebec Blue Collar — Landscaping, Agriculture, Construction, Demenagement
Model	B2B Staffing Marketplace — Company A delegates workers to Company B via Shift
Stage	MVP — Pre-launch research and product definition
Date	April 2026

This document covers the full product research, problem definition, platform model, actor flows, technical architecture, and go-to-market strategy for the Shift platform. It is the source of truth for all product decisions going into MVP build.

01 — Problem Definition

The core problem

Seasonal hiring in Quebec runs almost entirely on word of mouth and Kijiji ads. There is no digital infrastructure built specifically for how blue collar seasonal hiring actually works. This affects three parties simultaneously.

For employers (Company B)	For workers
• Post on Kijiji, receive 40 unqualified responses or zero • Best workers from last season are unreachable • No system for backup when a worker no-shows • Every season starts from zero — no persistent records • Scramble every April with no pipeline of reliable workers	• Find jobs through cousins, Facebook comments, pure luck • No way to build a verifiable work history • Employment gaps between seasons with no bridge • No platform that represents their identity and skills • Invisible to employers outside their personal network

The supplier problem — Company A

A landscaping company hires 8 workers for May through October. In November those workers sit idle or leave for competitors. The company loses its trained workforce every winter and has to rehire and retrain from scratch every spring. There is no mechanism to loan their idle workforce to a complementary business during the off-season and recover them in spring.

This is the core insight that separates Shift from a job board: we are not just connecting workers to jobs. We are enabling companies to share and circulate their workforce across seasons without losing them.

Why existing solutions fail

Platform	What it does	Why it fails blue collar
Indeed	Generic job board, resume upload	Built for office workers. Blue collar workers have no resume.
Jobillico	Quebec job board, similar to Indeed	Same problem. Treats a landscaper like an accountant.

Kijiji	Classifieds — free job posts	No verification, no trust, no reliability signal, spam-heavy.
Staffing agencies	Human-operated temp placement	Slow, expensive, phone-based, 20-30% commission. Not digital.
CCQ Placement	Union-based job placement	Only covers regulated CCQ trades. Landscaping and others excluded.

02 — Platform Model

The three actors

Shift is a three-sided marketplace. Every transaction involves all three parties simultaneously.

Company A — Supplier	Shift — Platform	Company B — Buyer
Has employees on payroll Has slow seasons where workers sit idle Wants to retain workers year-round Wants workers back in spring	Connects supply and demand Handles all payments via Stripe Takes percentage commission Manages trust and reliability	Needs workers urgently Does not want to hire full-time Wants verified reliable workers Pays Shift for placements

How the worker flows

The worker is employed by Company A. They are delegated to Shift during the off-season. Shift places them at Company B. When Company A's season returns, the worker goes back. The worker never experiences an employment gap.

01

Company A adds workers to Shift pool

Specifies which workers are available, for which sectors, and for what date range.

02

Company B posts a shift need

Specifies skills needed, dates, location, hours, and pay rate. Takes 3 minutes.

03

Shift matches and surfaces top worker

Algorithm scores available workers by skill, location, reliability, and availability. Shows best match to Company B.

04

Company A manually approves the placement

Receives a notification. Reviews the shift details. Approves or declines. Manual at MVP — automated later.

05

Worker receives shift notification via SMS

Company B name, location, hours, pay. One tap to accept or decline.

06

Worker clocks in via GPS

Opens app at Company B location. GPS verifies presence. Shift timer starts.

07

Worker clocks out — payment triggers automatically

Hours calculated. Stripe Connect splits payment: 15% to Shift, rest to Company A. Company B charged.

08

Both parties rate the experience

Worker rates employer. Employer rates worker. Reliability scores update. System ready for next placement.

Payment flow

All payments flow through Stripe Connect. Shift never touches money manually. Every split, payout, and receipt is automated.

Company B pays	Shift keeps	Company A receives
\$200.00 (8hrs @ \$25/hr)	\$30.00 (15% commission)	\$170.00 (pays worker from this)

Stripe Connect handles: split payments, automatic payouts, KYC verification, tax documents, fraud detection, and Canadian banking compliance. Shift never stores banking credentials.

03 — Market Research

Why Quebec

Quebec has a specific combination of conditions that makes it the ideal first market for Shift.

- Severe skilled trades shortage — construction industry needs tens of thousands of workers over the next decade
- DEP graduates receiving job offers before completing their program
- Highly seasonal economy — landscaping, agriculture, ski resorts, construction, festivals all have distinct seasons that complement each other
- Hydro-Quebec making Quebec a top data center destination — driving even more demand for trades workers
- French-first market that English platforms serve poorly — local advantage for a bilingual platform
- No digital infrastructure exists for blue collar seasonal work specifically

Target sectors — launch order

Sector	Season	CCQ regulated	Launch timing	Why
Landscaping	May-Oct	No	First	Zero regulation, spring urgency, dense in Montreal
Agriculture	June-Sept	No	First	Farms starving for workers, no digital tools
Demenagement	June-July	No	Month 2	July 1st Quebec moving day — built-in panic moment
Ski resorts	Dec-Mar	No	Month 3	Winter anchor — same workers as landscaping
Construction helpers	Apr-Nov	No	Month 4	Manoeuvres only — no CCQ required
Electricians	Year-round	YES	Never at MVP	CCQ regulated — legal exposure too high

Seasonal calendar — the complementary cycle

This is the core insight behind the worker circulation model. The seasons of Company A and Company B are designed to be complementary — not overlapping.

Sector	Jan	Feb	Mar	Apr	May	Jun	Jul	Aug	Sep	Oct	Nov	Dec
Landscaping				A	A	A	A	A	A			
Deneigement	B	B	B								B	B
Agriculture						A	A	A	A			
Ski resorts	B	B	B									B
Construction				A	A	A	A	A	A	A		

A = Company A active season B = Company B receives workers Blank = worker available to circulate

04 — MVP Scope

The MVP covers only the core loop. Everything else is post-launch. The goal is to get one Company A, one Company B, and one worker through the full flow — from signup to paid shift — as fast as possible.

What is in MVP

Actor	Feature	Screen
Company A	Sign up — company name, sector, phone	Signup form
Company A	Add workers to Shift pool with skills and availability	Worker management
Company A	Manually approve or decline shift requests	Approval screen
Company A	Receive weekly payout via Stripe	Payout dashboard
Company B	Sign up — company name, sector, phone	Signup form
Company B	Post shift need — skill, date, location, hours, pay	Shift request form
Company B	View matched worker profile and reliability score	Match preview
Company B	Confirm worker and prepay via Stripe	Payment screen
Company B	Confirm shift completed and rate worker	Completion screen
Worker	Create profile — photo, skills, location, availability	Profile screen
Worker	Receive shift notification via SMS	SMS + app notification
Worker	Accept or decline shift	Shift detail screen
Worker	Clock in via GPS verification	Clock in screen
Worker	Clock out — triggers payment split	Clock out screen

What is NOT in MVP — post-launch only

Deferred features	Why deferred
- Auto-approve rules engine for Company A - Season end circulation engine - Rehire pre-booking system - Real-time GPS live tracking dashboard	- Auto-approve: learn manual patterns first, then codify into rules - Circulation engine: need real seasonal data before building this - Feed: requires content creators and mass users to work

- Document and invoice auto-generation
- In-app messaging between parties
- Equipment marketplace
- Worker feed and brain rot content layer

- Equipment: separate product line, needs own validation
- Messaging: SMS is enough for MVP coordination

05 — Technical Architecture

Stack decision

One repo. One deployment. Clean internal folder separation by actor. This is a monolith with microservice-ready structure — not actual microservices. The overhead of 3 repos would slow MVP by months with zero benefit at this scale.

Layer	Tool	Why
Frontend	Next.js + TypeScript + Tailwind	One codebase for web and mobile web. App router. Already in your stack.
Backend	Next.js API routes	No separate Express server needed. Routes map to /worker, /employer, /system, /shared folders.
Database	PostgreSQL + Prisma	Type-safe queries, clean migrations, perfect with TypeScript. Railway for hosting.
Payments	Stripe Connect	The only tool built for this exact model. Handles splits, payouts, KYC, tax docs, Canadian banking.
SMS	Twilio	Blue collar workers read texts not emails. Every notification is an SMS. \$0.0079 per message.
GPS clock-in	Browser Geolocation API	Free. No extra tool. Worker opens app at site, GPS verifies location match.
Auth	NextAuth.js	Phone + SMS OTP via Twilio. No email or password needed for workers.
Admin panel	Retool	Drag and drop internal dashboard. Connects to your PostgreSQL directly. No code needed.
Analytics	PostHog	Free tier. User behaviour, funnel drop-off, feature usage. Required before any investor pitch.
Deployment	Vercel + Railway	Frontend on Vercel. Database on Railway. Under \$15/month until serious scale.

Folder structure

```
/shift-app /app /api /worker ← worker routes: signup, profile, clock-in, clock-out
/employer ← employer routes: signup, shift post, match, approve /system ←
matching engine, payment split, notifications /shared ← auth, JWT, DB models, utils
/prisma schema.prisma ← all DB models /components ← shared UI components
/lib ← Stripe, Twilio, Prisma client instances
```

Monthly infrastructure cost at MVP

Service	Plan	Cost
Vercel	Hobby (free)	\$0/month
Railway (PostgreSQL)	Starter	\$5/month
Twilio	Pay per use	< \$10/month at low volume
Cloudinary (photos)	Free tier	\$0/month
PostHog	Free tier	\$0/month
TOTAL		< \$15/month

06 — Go To Market

The sequencing rule

Get Company B to post a shift before opening worker sign-ups. Get Company A to add workers before Company B can see them. The platform must never be empty when a new actor signs up for the first time.

Week by week launch plan

**Week
1**

Call 20 landscaping companies in Montreal

Validate the pain. Get 5 to agree to post when you launch. Do not build anything yet.

**Week
2–3**

Design UI — Figma wireframes

Worker profile, shift request form, match screen, clock-in. Mobile-first. Show to employers for feedback.

**Week
3–6**

Build MVP

Auth, company signup, worker profile, shift posting, matching, Stripe Connect, SMS, GPS clock-in. Core loop only.

**Week
6**

Internal beta

Get 3 Company A, 3 Company B, 10 workers through the full flow manually. Fix everything that breaks.

**Week
7–8**

Public launch — Montreal landscaping only

Open sign-ups. Post in Facebook groups, CEGEP boards. First 50 employer postings free. Both co-founders on outreach full time.

**Week
8+**

Track everything and iterate

PostHog from day one. Time to first match, match acceptance rate, shift completion rate, repeat usage. Data drives every decision.

Outreach script — phone

"Bonjour [nom], je cofonde une plateforme qu'on est en train de lancer specifiquement pour les entreprises comme la votre au Quebec. J'essaie juste de comprendre comment vous trouvez vos travailleurs presentement pour la saison. Est-ce que vous avez deux minutes?"

Key question to ask after opening:

"C'est quoi votre plus gros probleme quand vient le temps d'embaucher au printemps?"

The word that resonates most with every blue collar employer in Quebec:

FIABLE. Not qualified. Not experienced. Not certified. Reliable. Use this word in every conversation and every piece of marketing.

LinkedIn content sequence

Post	Angle	Goal
1	AI infrastructure	Establish market authority. AI runs on blue collar hands. No product mention.
2	Quebec data centers	Double down with Quebec-specific data. Position as market expert.
3	Blue collar demand	DEP grads hired before graduating. Trades shortage data. Attract workers and employers.
4	Personal why	Investors buy founders first. Origin story. The Kijiji landscaper. The farm. The SME.
5	Word of mouth problem	Every season resets to zero. Data infrastructure problem. Shared by employers.
6	Teaser	Dropping something this week. No details. Builds anticipation.
MVP	Launch announcement	Platform live. Real numbers. Link in comments. This is the post that gets investor DMs.

07 — Key Rules

These are the principles that should never be violated regardless of what happens during build or launch.

01

Never touch CCQ regulated trades at MVP

Electricians, HVAC, plumbers — CCQ regulated. Legal exposure is startup-ending. Manoeuvres construction is your safe entry into trades.

02

Solve chicken and egg with B2B first

Get 10 Company B shift postings live before opening to Company A workers. Nobody joins an empty platform.

03

Manual approval before automation

Learn how Company A approves manually for 2 months. That behavior becomes the logic for auto-approve later.

04

Stripe Connect is non-negotiable

Never build your own payment split logic. Stripe Connect was built exactly for this model. Use it from day one.

05

SMS over push notifications

Blue collar workers read texts in 3 minutes. They do not check app notifications. Every critical trigger is an SMS via Twilio.

06

Reliability score is the moat

It is what makes Shift defensible against Kijiji and Indeed. Build it right from day one even if it is just a simple average. The data compounds.

07

One city before one province

Montreal landscaping only at launch. Dominate one micro-market completely before expanding. Spreading thin kills marketplaces.

08

Traction before funding

Investors want to see you talked to real people and something is live. Do not pitch before 4 weeks of real usage data and real numbers.

The platform that fixes seasonal hiring for blue collar workers in Quebec will be built by someone. Make sure it is you.